

Warning signs

WHEN TO CALL US · AFTER ANY PROCEDURE

Keep this with
your recovery guide

Most post-operative concerns are easy to resolve — sometimes with a quick phone call, sometimes on your own once you know what's normal. This page helps you tell the difference. **When in doubt, call.** We'd rather answer a quick question than have you worry at home.

Urgent — act right away

DON'T WAIT

- **Difficulty breathing** or swallowing
- **Signs of severe allergic reaction:** widespread hives, tongue swelling, wheezing
- **Rapidly spreading swelling** to your neck, under your tongue, or around your eye
- **Chest pain** or fainting

Call our office right away for the on-call provider. If you truly cannot breathe, or if chest pain is severe, call 911 or go to the ER.

Call our office

WITHIN HOURS

These apply after any oral surgery procedure:

- 1 Severe pain on day 3–5 that your medication doesn't help at all
- 2 Pain, swelling, or bad taste that returns *after* you'd started to feel better
- 3 Heavy bleeding that won't stop after 30–45 min of firm pressure
- 4 Swelling getting worse after day 3, or spreading beyond the surgical area
- 5 Fever over 101°F (38.3°C)
- 6 Numbness in your lip, chin, or tongue that isn't clearly improving by the next morning — call right away if it still feels completely frozen after the anesthetic should have worn off

💡 Is it dry socket?

If your medication brings pain down to a 2–3 out of 10, it's **not** dry socket. If the medication does **nothing at all**, that's the hallmark. Call us — easily treated.

💡 Is it an infection?

Watch the **direction** of your pain, not the amount. Each day should be better than the last. If you were improving and then it came back, call us.

PROCEDURE-SPECIFIC WARNING SIGNS

AFTER WISDOM TEETH

Jaw stiffness getting worse (not better) after day 5

AFTER A SINUS PROCEDURE

Air through your mouth when breathing through your nose, or liquid from your nose when you drink

AFTER SEDATION (FIRST 24H)

Severe confusion, trouble staying awake, or persistent vomiting

AFTER AN IMPLANT

The implant feels loose or moves when you touch it

AFTER A GUM GRAFT

The graft turns dark purple, blue, or black, or falls off

AFTER A BONE GRAFT

A large amount of graft material coming out, or membrane exposure getting worse

Normal — you don't need to call for:

These are all expected parts of healing and don't mean something is wrong.

- ✓ Pink-tinged saliva for the first 24 hours
- ✓ Mild bruising of the cheek, jaw, or neck
- ✓ Slight bad breath or odd taste for a few days
- ✓ Jaw stiffness that slowly improves each day
- ✓ Slightly altered sensation that's gradually improving
- ✓ Swelling peaking at 48–72 hours, then improving
- ✓ Yellow or whitish tissue in the socket (healing, not pus)
- ✓ Sutures dissolving or coming loose over 1–3 weeks
- ✓ A gum graft looking white or gray for 1–2 weeks
- ✓ A small metal healing cap visible at an implant site

*For after-hours concerns, call our office and follow the instructions to reach the on-call provider. **When in doubt, always call — we'd rather hear from you.***